

Looking back on a milestone month of rich tech harvest



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Last month had me contemplating several issues. The state of my expenses, for example, is a constant consumer of grey matter. Apart from practicing a Zen-like resolve to protect my bank account from relentless attacks by every online shopping website and their vivacious Diwali deal promotions, wondering about Elon Musk's "Mars or bust" attitude to colonizing the Red Planet if humanity's ever to survive long enough to escape our solar system (digit.in/Musk_Mars), and global warming – seeing October Heat in Mumbai has been as bad, if not worse, than the summer months – I also came to reflect upon my sister's exclamation of how "ridiculously easy it is to install Ubuntu on a machine" when she installed it on her laptop recently. While it's true, that wasn't the case just over a decade ago, when the world of Linux distros and installations was a cesspool of frustration and strictly not for n00bs.

Until Ubuntu came along in October 2004 that is. Good golly, has it really been 10 years? How time flies! In the world of technology, where there's so much churning and constant upheaval of software and products, it's easy to get overwhelmed and lose track of things that matter. More importantly, it becomes increasingly difficult to appreciate some of the most used software and services as they become part of the great digital habit of our life. It's both a compliment and testimony of Ubuntu's ubiquity, user-friendliness, and longevity that it's not only remained relevant -- in the vast world of Linux distros -- but actually grown to gain a substantial share of Linux machines operating in the world.

According to Canonical, which made the popular Linux distro, there are a whopping 25 million users of Ubuntu worldwide. Not a huge number, I get it, but not something to wholly discount either. Especially when you consider the fact that Ubuntu's focused completely towards the conversion of ordinary, non-geeky users of Windows over to a world dominated by The Circle of Friends and Tux logos. And they've been fairly successful in their mission in making Linux less-intimidating and more user-friendly than any other distro ever. It's safe to assume that Ubuntu's going strong

when compared to other Linux distros, if purely by their website's claim – in case you haven't read it before – The leading OS for PC, tablet, phone and cloud. There's certainly no lack of ambition there.

Something else I chanced upon last month (and left to contemplate upon) was the spreadsheet's 35th anniversary. That's right. While Microsoft Excel might be synonymous with spreadsheets today, long before its birth VisiCalc – the first spreadsheets program ever – debuted with the Apple II in October 1979 to widen the appeal of PCs from hobbyists and enthusiasts to mainstream business users. Since then, everything from grocery shopping lists to book keeping records of every large business on this planet, not to mention our monthly magazine storylist and comparison test tables, are maintained on spreadsheets. Apart from a web browser, a spreadsheet (either offline or cloud-based) is the second most important application I use on a daily basis. I'm sure it's the same for a lot of people around the world. It won't be an exaggeration to say the world runs on them. And to think all of this started from a program designed to be nothing more than a digital scratchpad really makes your head spin.

The sheer longevity and long-term impact of these products and services in our lives is a testimony to the vision of the people who played an instrumental role in their conception. And their ability to adapt with changing times, user tastes, market realities, and a million other factors to still remain popular. No easy feat to pull this off, believe you me.

The story of October and its tryst with technology breakthroughs doesn't just end at Ubuntu and Spreadsheets, as the month also witnessed the 12 year anniversary of Microsoft Windows XP and the 13th anniversary of the original iPod's release. How have these two products shaped the world, you think? Time to contemplate some more, looks like. 